

such as the rate at which information travels over the Internet. Several factors can influence how quickly data travels, including modem speed, bandwidth capacity, and Internet traffic levels.

Modem

An external box or internal circuitry that converts computer data into sound-range signals that can be transmitted over phone lines. First used to send telegrams, early modems alternated between two different tones. This is called modulation, and the process of modulating, and demodulating at the receiving end, gave the modem its name. These days, modems transmit data with lots of different tones, signals, and complex mathematical processing, so ‘modem’ is a bit of a misnomer.

NAT

Network Address Translation. NAT solves both security and efficiency issues surrounding Internet use by letting a network at, say, a company, use its own pool of IP addresses for internal communications and another pool of addresses for external communications. This method hides internal IP addresses from hackers. In addition, because NAT lets the same IP addresses be used internally by multiple companies, it reduces the demand for globally unique, static IP addresses.

NIC

Network Interface Card; an adapter inside a computer that lets the computer connect to a network via a wired or wireless transmission medium.

OFDM

Orthogonal Frequency Division Multiplexing. A wireless transmission technique that splits a signal into smaller signals that are then transmitted at different frequencies simultaneously. It’s the method employed for wireless transmissions that use the IEEE 802.11a and 802.11g specifications.